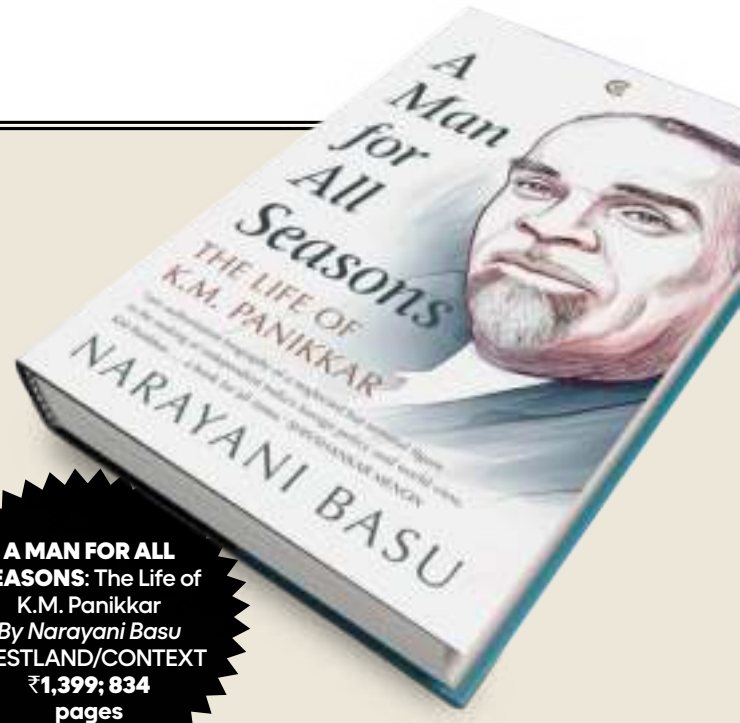
BOOKS ▼

A Life Larger Than History

NARAYANI BASU'S *A MAN FOR ALL SEASONS* BRINGS K.M. PANIKKAR'S DAZZLINGLY VARIED LIFE—SCHOLAR, DIPLOMAT, HISTORIAN—VIVIDLY BACK INTO THE SPOTLIGHT



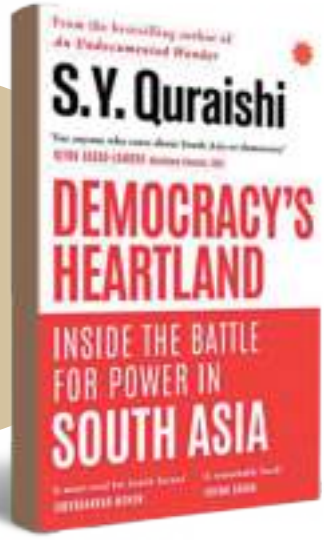
A MAN FOR ALL SEASONS: The Life of K.M. Panikkar
By Narayani Basu
WESTLAND/CONTEXT
₹1,399; 834 pages

A

A Man for All Seasons, through which biographer Narayani Basu tracks the crowded and intensively lived life of K.M. Panikkar, is both finely crafted and immensely readable despite its voluminous 800-plus pages. Panikkar hailed from a modest family in present-day Kerala, but was a precocious child, absorbing, like a veritable sponge, the swirling intellectual currents of his time. The first decades of the 20th century were when history was being made. India was caught up in the political and social maelstrom, struggling to throw off the yoke of colonialism but having to navigate a complex political landscape of feudal principalities, communal and linguistic fault lines but layered with nascent modernity. Panikkar embodied all these currents in his eventful life, serving successively in the princely kingdoms of Patiala, Kashmir and Bikaner, as a Congress Party functionary and as a diplomat serving independent India. Basu captures his multi-faceted personality in language that gives fulsome credit but acknowledges his weaknesses and vulnerabilities in equal measure. What is unique about this biography is the skill with which the author uses the prism of

THE LISTICLE

RECENT BOOK RELEASES THAT SHOULD BE ON YOUR READING LIST



DEMOCRACY'S HEARTLAND Inside the Battle for Power in South Asia
By S.Y. Quraishi
Juggernaut
₹799; 520 pages

Reframing the Narrative

This book by former chief election commissioner of India S.Y. Quraishi sets out to right a wrong. "A striking paradox in contemporary global discourse on democracy is the relative marginalisation of South Asia as a collective democratic space. Despite the region encompassing nearly a quarter of the world's population and 40 per cent of the world's democracy, and also hosting some of the most complex and enduring democratic practices, it remains under-represented in comparative democratic scholarship," he says in the Introduction. Despite all the volatility South Asia has been subject to—from Pakistan's failed experiment with democracy, Nepal's constitutional churn and Afghanistan's sharp descent into extremism—it is Quraishi's argument that no region has embraced democracy with more gusto than the Indian subcontinent. *Democracy's Heartland* is a definitive portrait of South Asia's tryst with democracy, warts and all.